

MARKETING SWEET · ROLEPLAY 07

The 80% Likable First Meeting

Session tie-in: Session 07 — 80% Likable, 20% Technical, Always

Difficulty: Intermediate · **Run time:** ~18 min · **Reps required:** 2

The setup

You're at the office of **Priya Patel**, principal of *Patel Tax & Advisory* — 6-person accounting practice, specialising in small-business and trades clients. She's been running her practice for 9 years. She's smart, careful with her time, and slightly skeptical — she's been pitched by three other agencies in the last six weeks.

You have 60 minutes. Affordability — likely fine (she's a partner in a healthy practice). Intent — uncertain (her current website is OK, not great, and she's known she needs to do something about it for over a year). Likability — completely untested. *This is the only pin you'll move in this meeting.*

Priya's first words to you when you sat down were polite but neutral: *"Right. So. Tell me what's different about you versus the last three agencies I've spoken to."*

You are the rep.

Coaching note — before you start: Most reps will hear that opening question and *immediately* go technical — feature dumps, case studies, differentiators. That is the exact wrong move. Going technical signals you're a salesperson trying to win her business. Going 80% likable signals you're a human she might want to do business with. This roleplay is the test for whether a rep can resist the technical-pitch instinct under pressure.

THE SCRIPT

REP: *[Smiles, settles in, doesn't reach for laptop]* Priya, fair question — and I'll come back to it. Genuinely — before we get into us, I want to understand more about *Patel Tax & Advisory* first. You've got six staff — is that all CAs or a mix? And how do you sit on the workload — are you taking new clients or are you full?

Coaching note: That's the entire move. She asked you a technical question; you deflected with curiosity. Not aggressively, not awkwardly — politely. "I'll come back to it" is the magic phrase because it doesn't refuse her question; it postpones it. By the time you "come back to it," you'll have ten minutes of context that makes your answer ten times sharper. And she'll have started liking you.

PRIYA: *[Slight smile — surprised]* It's two CAs, two senior accountants, one junior, and an admin. We're slightly above capacity at the moment — we're turning some work away.

REP: That must be a hard call to make — turning work away. How do you decide what to keep and what to send on?

Coaching note: Session 07 — asymmetric question. “That must be a hard X” works in both directions. If she agrees (“yeah, it’s brutal”), you’ve built empathy. If she pushes back (“actually it’s pretty clear-cut for us”), you’ve handed her a chance to show off, which she’ll enjoy. Either way you’ve built connection.

PRIYA: It’s mostly about whether they’re a long-term fit. We’ll turn down quick-turnaround tax-return-only clients to keep capacity for the small-business advisory work. That’s where the real value sits.

REP: That makes sense — advisory’s where the lasting client relationships are. Who do you work with most — trades, hospo, professional services?

PRIYA: Mostly trades — about 60% of our book. Builders, electricians, plumbers. Some hospitality and a handful of professional services.

REP: *[Genuine response, not a sales pivot]* That’s basically our world too — Marketing Sweet’s book is 70% trades. Different services obviously, but I’d bet there’s a lot of crossover in the kinds of conversations you and we have with those clients. Half my week is a tradesman trying to figure out why a competitor with worse work and worse customer service is getting more leads. Sounds like your week’s “why is my tax bill up when my revenue’s the same” three times a day.

PRIYA: *[Laughs]* Honestly, that’s accurate.

Coaching note: That’s a connection moment. You showed you actually understand her clients’ world by giving her a specific, accurate observation about it. Not a generic compliment — a real one. That’s worth more than any case study you could have shown her in the first ten minutes.

REP: Going to ask you a slightly random question — does that ever wear on you? Three clients in a week asking you the same thing — I imagine it’s a hard line to walk between giving them the time and not setting yourself on fire.

Coaching note: Now you’re asking about her, not about her business. This is the line between technical rapport-building (which is extractive) and real connection (which isn’t). Don’t expect to do this on the first try — most reps need to practise getting past their own discomfort with the question.

PRIYA: *[Pauses — actually thinks]* Yeah. Yeah, it does. I love the work but I think six staff is the wrong size — it’s too big to do everything myself and too small to delegate without checking everything. We’ve been at this size for two years and I’m not sure if I want to grow or stay tight.

Coaching note: That’s gold. Priya just told you the *real* strategic question on her mind — and it has *nothing* to do with marketing. But this is now the conversation she actually wants to have, and you’ve earned it.

REP: That's a real one. And honestly — what you do online will look really different depending on which way you go. If you're staying at six, the goal is filtering for the right clients, not volume. If you're growing, the goal is the opposite — visibility, breadth, lead flow. That's actually probably the most important thing for me to understand today, before I tell you anything about what we do.

Coaching note: Notice — you've now answered her opening question ("what's different about you?") indirectly. The difference is that *you asked her something the other three agencies didn't*. You let the technical conversation come last, and only if she wanted it.

PRIYA: *[Pauses]* I think — yeah, look, I think growth is on the cards. Carefully. I don't want to be twenty staff. But ten? Probably the right number.

REP: Okay. That's super helpful. Can I do this — let me ask you another five or six things about how you work, what your ideal client looks like, where your current website's letting you down — and I'll give you a sense at the end of whether we'd be a fit and what it'd look like. If it's not a fit, you'll know and I'll know. Fair?

PRIYA: Fair.

Coaching note: You've now built 80% likability with a prospect who walked in cold and skeptical. You haven't pitched anything. You haven't shown a case study. You haven't named a price. And you've earned the next 50 minutes — by going slow on the first 10. That's the Session 07 move. The technical 20% will land much harder now than it would have at minute one.

THE FORK — Priya doesn't open up:

PRIYA: Look, I'm short on time. Can you just run through what makes you different from the others? I've heard four pitches in six weeks and they all sound the same.

Coaching note: She's pressing on the technical question again. Don't keep deflecting — at some point that becomes weird. Be honest about *why* you're going slow and then deliver a sharp answer.

REP: Totally fair. Quick answer: most agencies will tell you what they do — SEO, content, AdWords, blah. We do all that too. The *actual* difference is that we work almost exclusively with trade and professional services businesses in your size range, so the strategy we build is tailored to how your clients actually find you, not a generic playbook. The reason I was asking about your business first is that I'd rather build the picture before I tell you the conclusion. Otherwise I'm just pitching at you, which is exactly what the other three were doing. Want me to keep going on the questions, or do you want me to walk you through some examples first?

Coaching note: You acknowledged her point, gave a sharp answer, then made the *technical-first vs slow-first* decision *her* call. Most prospects will say "no, keep

going on the questions” because you’ve just made them part of the choice. That builds more likability.

STRETCH VARIATIONS

- **Priya steps on a landmine — “What do you think about the government’s small-business tax changes?”** Session 07’s three landmines (religion, politics, money/policy). Even though she raised it, don’t take a position. “Honestly, I steer clear of policy debate with clients — too easy to land on the wrong side. Curious whether the changes have been net positive or net negative for your practice?” — neutral, asymmetric, redirects to her without engaging.
 - **Priya tells you she’s already decided on another agency.** Don’t fight it. “Fair enough — sounds like you’ve done the work. Can I ask who, just out of curiosity? Not to pitch against them — just to understand the market.” Most prospects will tell you. That’s market intelligence you can use elsewhere, and you’ve still ended on likable terms — she might come back in six months if it doesn’t work out.
 - **Priya is much more guarded than the script suggests.** Don’t push harder. Match her energy. Some prospects need three meetings to open up. Win the second meeting, not this one.
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WHAT TO LOOK FOR WHEN YOU’RE PRACTISING THIS

- Did the rep resist the urge to go technical when Priya asked the differentiator question?
- Did they use the “I’ll come back to that” phrase, or did it feel like a refusal?
- Did they ask Priya about her clients in a way that was specific (60% trades, etc.) or generic?
- Did they ask the “does that wear on you” question, or stay business-only?
- When Priya pushed for the technical answer, did the rep deflect a third time (wrong) or deliver a sharp answer (right)?

This is the hardest roleplay because the technique is “go slow when every instinct says go fast.” Run it five times before you expect a rep to feel comfortable. The first two runs will feel forced. By run four, it starts to feel natural — and that’s when it actually starts to land in real meetings.